Princess and the Hustler: Character Quotations

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Princess & The Hustler: Key Character Quotations

Examiners will be looking for evidence of your ability to interpret pivotal moments in the novel and analyse how themes, characters and their actions within the text convey meaning and add dramatic effect. Here we will examine some important quotations from the following key characters:

- Wendell
- Princess (Phyllis)
- Mavis
- Margot
- Wendell "Junior"

Wendell

> **"Tink of de children"** — Act 1, Scene 3

Key word or phrase to memorise: "Tink", "children"	**What the quotation means:** After turning up unexpectedly at Mavis' door on Christmas day with his daughter Lorna, Wendell appeals to Mavis' sense of compassion when he asks Mavis to provide a place for them to stay	**Theme**: Family
• Wendell asking Mavis to think about the welfare of their children is deeply ironic — it is Wendell who has left the raising of the children to Mavis for a number of years: ○ This reflects on Wendell's initial presentation in the play — he arguably lacks empathy for Mavis and displays a level of entitlement in expecting Mavis to help him		

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

- This line can be contrasted to later scenes involving Wendell's tender relationship with Princess:
  - In the final scene when he places the "crown" on her head in their mock pageant, Wendell is more thoughtful about his own children

> **"When mi come to dis country I was… Ar soldier.**
> **Fight far King an' country.**
> **But it never make far respec'"** — Wendell, Act 1, Scene 7

Key word or phrase to memorise: "King an' country", " respec'"	**What the quotation means:** In the process of trying to explain to his son why he left the family, Wendell explains that he has been mistreated due to his background, in spite of his service to the country	**Theme**: Belonging and identity

- Wendell highlights the contribution he has made in service of Britain, as part of the **Windrush Generation** of immigration, has not been valued:
  - The **alliterative** phrase "King an' country" echoes the phrasing used to inspire patriotism and loyalty in wartime, particularly from World War 1 onwards:
    - Wendell suggests that it has been particularly hurtful to have experienced discrimination and a lack of respect after his contribution
- Odimba's use of both **dialect** words ("far", "mi") and the way Wendell's **accent** is written **phonetically** ("respec'") emphasises his sense of otherness and the lack of belonging he feels in England

> **"If a whole city can try to change, why not one simple man?"** — Mavis, Act 2, Scene 4

Key word or phrase to memorise: "change"	**What the quotation means:** In a conversation with Margot, in which Margot is sceptical of Wendell's capacity to change, Mavis expresses hope that, like the political change brought about the Bristol Bus Boycott, Wendell too can change	**Theme:** Family

- Mavis creates a parallel between the positive changes brought about in Bristol through the bus boycotts and Wendell's newfound commitment to her family
- Odimba uses Wendell's character as a symbol here: his unlikely transformation mirrors the opening up of employment opportunities to people of colour in Bristol:
  - This may also have been seen as unlikely at the time by characters in the play

> **"Mi see all our dreams coming together Mavis… Hustle nuh win anything far mi"** — Wendell, Act 3, Scene 4

Key word or phrase to memorise: "dreams", 'Hustle nuh win"	**What the quotation means:** In the **penultimate** scene of the play, Wendell has asked Mavis to re-marry him, though she doesn't refuse, she also reminds him that he needs to be a more upright role model to his children — advice which he humbly accepts	**Theme:** Family

- The recognition that "hustle" cannot "win" anything for Wendell signals a transition away from the deceitful qualities suggested by the **titular** label of "hustler":
  - Wendell's rejection of this label is a stark contrast to earlier scenes that suggest he once embraced the role:
    - For example, when he wins money playing cards at the docks in Act 1, Scene 6, or boasts to Margot about the skills he had when he used to "hustle proper" in Act 2, Scene 7
- Wendell's metaphorical use of the word "dreams" here is deeply **symbolic** of hope:
  - The word echoes his earlier question about whether Mavis is willing to involve him in her family's "dreams" and the joyous final scene in which Princess' fantastical world of "pageantry" is "just as she [dreamt] it"

Help me understand

Princess (Phyllis)

Key word or phrase to memorise: "explodes", "pageantry"	What the quotation means: At the start and end of the play, Princess reimagines a "cupboard room" in her Bristol home as a lavishly decorated stage in Weston-super-Mare, where she is crowned the winner of a beauty pageant	Theme: Belonging and identity

• Odimba uses a **cyclical structure** to include the celebratory image of Princess being crowned the winner of the pageant:
  ◦ Pageantry suggests celebration and the play ends on a celebratory note
  ◦ The crown is both literal and **symbolic**:
  ▪ While the "cardboard and tinsel" it is made of shows how vividly Princess has imagined her victory at the pageant, the image of a crown has connotations of royalty and self-worth
  ▪ By the end of the play, this reinforces the celebration of the value and pride implied by the name "Princess"
• These opening and closing scenes are a stark contrast to the end of Act 2, where she has lost faith in her own sense of value:
  ◦ In Act 2, Scene 5, Princess' "world of pageantry doesn't come alive" and she "destroys her cupboard world"		

> **"They tell me to go away. Go back to where I came from. What does that mean?"** — Princess, Act 3, Scene 2

Key word or phrase to memorise: "go back"	What the quotation means: Princess expresses confusion about the racist treatment she has experienced from peers at school	Theme: Belonging and identity

• Odimba presents Princess' naivety and lack of understanding about the racist treatment she has received at school:
  ◦ This exposes the cruel treatment that black people in the UK would have been susceptible to in the 1960s:
  ▪ The idea that Princess might "go back" to where she came from is **ironic**: she was born in England and is a British citizen		

> **“And now watch everything beautiful in the world come alive…”** — Princess, Act 3, Scene 6

Key word or phrase to memorise: “beautiful”, “come alive”	**What the quotation means:** In the last lines of dialogue in the play, Princess refers to the unfolding of the beauty pageant, which her family members are now involved in	**Theme:** Belonging and identity

• The pageant is no longer just a figment of Princess’ imagination and ur now “come[s] alive” in part because of the involvement of her family members
• Princess having the final line in the play is structurally significant:
  ○ It gives those lines extra importance and means that the play ends with the joyous idea of her celebration
• “everything beautiful” is **ambiguous** here:
  ○ While on the surface Princess seems to be referring to the beauty pageant, it could also suggest hope for the future of Princess’ newly united family or for the black residents of Bristol		

Mavis

> **"lowers the knife slowly and hides it behind her back"**
> — Stage direction, Act 1, Scene 3

Key word or phrase to memorise: **“**knife”, “hides”	**What the quotation means:** After threatening Wendell with a knife after he turns up unexpectedly at her home on Christmas day, Mavis hides the knife when Wendell presents Lorna, his 9–year-old daughter from another relationship	**Theme:** Family

symbolic of the extent she is willing to go to to defend her family
    - The way that Mavis "lowers" the knife and "hides" it when she sees Lorna is comical, but also shows how empathetic Mavis is:
        - Her instinct is to protect Lorna

> **"What about these hands that been doing the work of two people?"** — Mavis, Act 2, Scene 1

Key word or phrase to memorise: "hands", "work"	**What the quotation means:** When Wendell becomes flirtatious and compliments Mavis' legs, she redirects the conversation to remind him of how hard she has had to work to support the family in his absence	**Themes:** Family

• Mavis has had to work tirelessly to support her children without Wendell:
  ○ "Hands" are **symbolic** of both care and labour:
  ▪ Mavis has not only been raising the children, but "sewing till [her] fingers turn blue" as part of her self-employed work		

> **"I want to survive long enough for my children to feel like this their home too. That's all I have the strength for these days"** — Mavis, Act 2, Scene 4

Key word or phrase to memorise: "their home"	**What the quotation means:** Mavis explains to Margot that her energy is focused not on trying to change Wendell, but on supporting her children	**Themes:** Family, belonging and identity, activism and protest

• Mavis rejects Margot's argument that Wendell's involvement of her family in the Bristol Bus Boycott is detrimental to them:
  ○ Mavis wishes that they 'feel like this their home too' is a clear indication of her support for those protests
  ○ Her use of **dialect** speech here ("this their home") uses ellipsis to suggest that the family's Jamaican cultural identity can exist alongside their lives in England		

- She also sounds weary: “survive long enough” and “all I have the strength for” suggest exhaustion

> **“The James family going to celebrate this win today!”**
> — Mavis, Act 3, Scene 5

Key word or phrase to memorise: “family”, “win”	**What the quotation means:** Mavis states that they are going to celebrate the success of the Bristol Bus Boycott and the lifting of the **colour bar**	**Themes:** Family, activism and protest

• Mavis referring to the “James family” as a complete unit, including Lorna and Wendell, is a stark contrast to the opening scenes in which Mavis turns Wendell away from her home
• Mavis refers explicitly to the “win” of the bus boycott, which shows that, like Wendell and Junior, she has become enthused by the protests:
  ○ This is a contrast to earlier in the play where Mavis viewed the sacrifices she would have to make in order to participate in the bus boycott as an inconvenience:
  ▪ “How am I meant to get up the hills by Totterdown?” (Act 2, Scene 1)		

Margot

> **“Come on mi babbers. Let’s be having some dressing up!”** — Margot, Act 1, Scene 5

Key word or phrase to memorise:	**What the quotation means:** Aware that Wendell’s return has created tension, Margot offers to take Princess and Lorna to her home, to do an activity that Princess enjoys	**Theme:** Family
• Margot is presented here as empathetic and as being close to Mavis’ family: ○ “Babbers” is Bristolian **dialect**, literally meaning ‘baby’, which is used as a term of affection here by Margot		

and Mavis and sees an opportunity to give them a moment to talk alone, protecting the children from the tension

Paired quotations:

> **"She's a good sort and not one to rock the boat that brought her here"** — Margot, Act 2, Scene 2

> **"Don't get me wrong. You're alright. I mean I know you. I knows many of your lot"** — Margot, Act 2, Scene 2

Key word or phrase to memorise: "sort", "your lot"	**What the quotation mean:** In a tense exchange with Wendell, Margot is dismissive of the Bristol Bus Boycott and suggests that his involvement of Mavis in activism might be perceived as a lack of gratitude for being accepted in Bristol	**Themes:** Activism and protest; identity and belonging

• In spite of Margot's close friendship with Mavis, she uses language about Jamaican migrants that is "othering":
  ○ The **metaphor** of "rock[ing] the boat" implies that Mavis and her family should be grateful for having been accepted into English society and that agitating for more rights might be seen as **antagonistic**
  ○ The word "boat" also serves as an unfortunate **symbol** of otherness: it alludes to the arrival of Jamaican migrants to the UK
  ○ By referring to "your lot" and suggesting to Wendell that he is "alright", Margot also exposes her potential disapproval of other black residents
  ○ Labelling Margot as a "good sort" perhaps illustrates a tendency to make assumptions, possibly negative ones, about large groups of black residents of Bristol		

> **"And you're always welcome here. Any time"** — Margot, Act 3, Scene 3

"welcome"	tells Margot she is always welcome there as part of her family.	

- By the end of the play, Margot's close relationship with Mavis has been repaired:
  - Returning Princess safely to Mavis' household once again shows the care has for Mavis and her family
  - The stage directions in this scene show a "tear run[ning] down Margot's cheek" in response to Mavis' statement, indicating how much their relationship means to her
  - This is a contrast to the distance and tension between Margot and Mavis in Act 2, Scene 4, in which Margot criticises Wendell and the bus boycotts:
    - The scene ends with Margot leaving and Mavis not speaking or "look[ing] up"

Wendell "Junior"

> **"It's just… I can't… leave my sisters"** — Wendell Junior, Act 1, Scene 7

Key word or phrase to memorise: "can't", "my sisters"	**What the quotation means:** When Leon mentions that his father is organising a meeting in relation to protesting the **colour bar**, Wendell Junior expresses his desire to attend, but also that he feels obligated to stay with his sisters	**Themes:** Family, activism and protest

- Wendell Junior is very protective of his sisters: his instinct to keep them safe overrides his desire to go to a protest meeting with Leon:
  - The pronoun "my" emphasises his protectiveness; it is particularly significant that he refers this way to Lorna, who is his half-sister and whom he has only met very recently
  - The use of ellipses shows that he is conflicted: he also feels that he should be involved in the protests against the **colour bar**

Paired quotations:

> **"You're the worst father any family can ask for"** — Wendell Junior, Act 3, Scene 4

Key word or phrase to memorise: "worst"	**What the quotations mean:** Wendell Junior, at various points in the play, criticises Wendell for being an absent father	**Theme:** Family

• Wendell is bitter about his father's return, and resents the fact that he has been absent so long:
  ○ Odimba uses the **juxtaposition** of the words "hate" and "love" to show that Wendell Junior is protective of his family and prioritises them above his own financial interests
  ○ Towards the end of the play, Wendell Junior (wrongly) assumes that Wendell has stolen the money he previously offered:
  ▪ He uses the **superlative** "worst" to show that his feelings against his father have become even more passionate
  ○ Both of these scenes contrast with the **penultimate** scene, in which Wendell Junior includes Wendell in his family photograph, signalling acceptance		

Source

Odimba, Chinonyerem. (2019) *Princess & The Hustler*. Nick Hern Books

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